Mayoral Partisanship and its Effect on Housing Cost

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Abstract

This project examines whether the partisan affiliation of city mayors is associated with housing market outcomes in U.S. cities. Using a city-level panel dataset covering the period from 2005 to 2019, the study analyzes the relationship between mayoral partisanship and future housing price growth. Housing market performance is measured using forward-looking percentage changes in median home values over multiple time horizons. The empirical analysis employs panel regression models with city and year fixed effects to account for persistent differences between cities and broader national economic trends.

The results suggest that mayoral party affiliation alone does not have a strong or consistent relationship with future housing price growth. While political leadership may influence local housing policy, broader structural factors such as regional economic conditions, housing supply constraints, and state-level policy environments appear to play a larger role in shaping housing market outcomes.

These findings highlight the limits of attributing housing market performance to municipal political leadership alone. Future research may benefit from incorporating additional political and institutional factors, such as state-level partisanship or the interaction between executive and legislative political control, to better understand how political institutions influence housing markets.

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1 Introduction

Housing markets have become one of the most economically and politically consequential arenas in the United States. Over the past two decades, rapid appreciation in home values, persistent affordability crises, and increasing spatial inequality have elevated housing from a local planning issue to a central political concern. In most American cities, local governments control zoning, land-use regulation, development approval processes, and housing supply decisions. Because these decisions directly shape housing production and market dynamics, local political leadership may play a critical role in determining housing outcomes.

At the same time, political polarization in the United States has increasingly extended into local governance. While national partisan differences in fiscal and redistributive policy are well documented, less is known about whether partisan control at the municipal level systematically influences housing market outcomes. Mayors often set development agendas, influence planning departments, negotiate with developers, and shape regulatory environments. If partisan ideology affects attitudes toward regulation, development, density, and property taxation, then mayoral partisanship may plausibly influence housing supply constraints and, ultimately, housing prices.

This paper asks: *Does mayoral partisanship influence housing market outcomes, specifically median home values and their growth rates, across U.S. cities?* More precisely, I examine whether cities governed by Republican versus Democratic mayors experience systematically different levels or trajectories of median home value appreciation over time.

At the same time, identifying the causal effect of local political leadership on housing markets is challenging. Housing prices are shaped by a wide range of structural forces including regional economic growth, interest rates, migration patterns, and land supply constraints. Many of these factors operate at the metropolitan or national level and may overshadow the influence of local political actors. Moreover, cities differ substantially in geography, economic composition, and regulatory institutions, which may limit the extent to which a mayor can meaningfully alter housing supply conditions in the short run. As a result, empirical analysis must account for persistent differences across cities as well as common shocks affecting housing markets nationwide.

Theoretically, partisan effects on housing markets may operate through multiple channels. Republican mayors may favor deregulation, streamlined permitting, and pro-development policies that increase housing supply, potentially moderating price growth. Alternatively, Democratic mayors may support inclusionary zoning, affordable housing mandates, or rent regulation, which could either constrain supply or reshape market composition. Because housing markets are sensitive to regulatory environments, even marginal differences in local political leadership may generate measurable effects on price dynamics.

To evaluate this question, I construct a panel dataset of U.S. cities spanning 2005–2019 that combines annual median home value data with information on mayoral party affiliation. I estimate regression models that exploit within-city variation over time to assess whether changes in partisan control are associated with changes in housing values and their growth

rates. By incorporating both level and multi-year percent change measures, this analysis captures both short-run and medium-run housing dynamics.

This study contributes to the literature in three ways. First, it extends research on the political economy of housing by shifting attention from national welfare state outcomes to local housing market performance. Second, it builds on scholarship examining whether local elected officials matter for policy outcomes by focusing on a highly salient economic indicator. Third, it provides new empirical evidence on whether partisan control at the municipal level shapes one of the most pressing economic challenges facing American cities: housing affordability.

Understanding whether mayoral partisanship affects housing values is critical not only for evaluating local political accountability but also for informing debates about regulatory reform and urban governance. If partisan control meaningfully shapes housing outcomes, then electoral politics may be a central mechanism through which housing supply and affordability are determined.

2 Related Work

2.1 Mayoral Partisanship and Local Policy

A substantial body of research examines whether partisan control at the municipal level meaningfully shapes policy outcomes. Although cities operate within institutional and fiscal constraints imposed by state and federal governments, recent work demonstrates that mayoral ideology can influence local priorities.

Einstein and Glick Einstein and Glick (2018) provide direct evidence that mayoral partisanship affects redistributive policy preferences. Using interviews, surveys, and public statements from U.S. mayors, they show that Democratic mayors are significantly more likely than Republican mayors to prioritize redistributive initiatives. Importantly, they find that partisan differences persist even after accounting for economic and institutional contexts, suggesting that ideology influences policy direction at the local level.

Similarly, Gerber and Hopkins Gerber and Hopkins (2011) examine whether mayoral party affiliation affects fiscal allocations across U.S. cities. Employing a regression discontinuity design, they find that Democratic mayors allocate a smaller share of municipal budgets to public safety compared to Republican or Independent mayors, particularly in policy areas where cities retain greater discretion. Their results indicate that partisanship has measurable effects when institutional constraints are limited.

These findings challenge the traditional view that municipal governments operate largely as administrative units with limited ideological variation. Instead, the evidence suggests that partisan preferences can shape how local leaders allocate resources and prioritize policy objectives. While cities face substantial constraints from state and federal institutions, mayors retain influence over agenda setting, administrative coordination, and regulatory implementation. Consequently, even within constrained institutional environments, polit-

ical ideology may still shape policy choices that affect local economic conditions.

Together, these studies establish that local partisanship can shape municipal policy outcomes, particularly in areas where city leaders possess meaningful authority.

2.2 Partisanship and Housing Policy

Recent scholarship increasingly demonstrates that partisan politics influences local housing policy in the United States. Using data from thousands of mayoral and city council elections in large American cities, de Benedictis-Kessner, Jones, and Warshaw de Benedictis-Kessner, Jones and Warshaw (2025) find that electing Democratic mayors leads to greater production of multifamily housing units, indicating that partisan leadership can shape the composition of the housing stock through policy decisions affecting development and land use. More broadly, research on local political representation Aniza (2021) shows that party and ideology are increasingly important in municipal governance, with growing evidence that local policy outcomes reflect partisan preferences and ideological differences among elected officials. While earlier work often portrayed local governments as largely managerial and insulated from partisan conflict, recent studies suggest that local policy areas—including housing and land-use regulation—may reflect the same partisan dynamics observed in state and national politics.

In the U.S. context, Ferreira and Gyourko Ferreira and Gyourko (2026) directly examine whether political partisanship affects housing supply across cities. Using panel data and regression analysis, they evaluate whether cities under different partisan leadership exhibit systematic differences in housing production. Their work provides direct evidence on whether ideology influences housing market outcomes through supply-side mechanisms.

Together, these studies highlight the importance of political institutions in shaping urban development patterns. Housing supply decisions often emerge from complex interactions between zoning regulations, planning approval processes, and local political incentives. Because mayors and city councils frequently influence these processes, partisan ideology may indirectly affect housing market outcomes through the regulatory environment faced by developers. However, while existing work documents political effects on housing policy decisions, less research evaluates whether these policy differences translate into observable changes in housing market performance.

This literature suggests that housing markets may be sensitive to political leadership, particularly where local governments influence zoning, planning, and development approvals.

2.3 Contribution

Building on this literature, the present study examines whether partisan leadership affects not only policy inputs, such as spending allocations or housing approvals, but also measurable housing market outcomes. Specifically, this paper analyzes whether mayoral partisanship predicts forward-looking home price growth across U.S. cities.

Where prior work primarily focuses on fiscal allocations or housing supply decisions, this study evaluates whether partisan control translates into observable changes in housing prices over one- to five-year horizons. By combining panel regression methods with city and year fixed effects, this analysis isolates within-city variation over time, allowing for a more direct assessment of whether political leadership correlates with housing market performance.

In doing so, this paper contributes to the growing literature on local political economy by testing whether partisan differences extend beyond policy preferences and into realized market outcomes. In addition, focusing on housing prices provides a broader indicator of housing market dynamics than policy inputs alone. While zoning decisions and housing approvals capture regulatory intentions, housing prices reflect the combined effects of supply constraints, demand pressures, and development activity. Examining whether partisan leadership correlates with price growth therefore provides a complementary perspective on the political determinants of urban housing markets.

3 Data

3.1 Dataset Description

The dataset used in this study combines information on housing market outcomes and mayoral political affiliation for a panel of U.S. cities. Housing market data consist of annual median home values at the city level covering the period from 2005 to 2019. These data capture the overall price level of residential housing markets and provide a consistent measure of housing value across time and locations.

Political data were collected to identify the partisan affiliation of each city's mayor for every year in the dataset. The key political variable records whether the mayor was affiliated with the Republican Party or not during a given city-year. Combining these sources produces a city-level panel dataset that links local political leadership to housing market outcomes over time.

The final dataset is structured at the city-year level, allowing the analysis to track changes within cities across multiple years while also comparing outcomes across different cities.

3.2 Data Cleaning and Preprocessing

Several preprocessing steps were required to prepare the dataset for analysis. First, housing value data and political data were merged using city and year identifiers. Also, data was filtered to only include cities that experienced at least one mayoral party change within the targeted time period (2005-2019). Observations with missing values in key variables were removed to ensure consistency across the panel.

Next, the dataset was checked for duplicate entries and inconsistencies in city identifiers.

After merging and cleaning, the data were organized into a balanced panel format where each observation corresponds to a specific city and year.

To reduce the influence of extreme values and to focus on dynamic changes in housing markets, the analysis emphasizes changes in housing values rather than raw price levels.

3.3 Feature Engineering

To examine how political leadership relates to housing market performance, several new variables were constructed from the raw housing price data.

First, forward-looking percent change variables were created to measure housing price growth over different time horizons. These variables calculate the percentage change in median home value between the current year and future years. Specifically, the following measures were constructed:

- One-year forward percent change in median home value
- Two-year forward percent change in median home value
- Three-year forward percent change in median home value
- Four-year forward percent change in median home value
- Five-year forward percent change in median home value

These forward-looking measures allow the analysis to examine whether the partisan affiliation of mayors is associated with future housing market performance rather than only contemporaneous price levels.

Additionally, an indicator variable was constructed to represent mayoral partisanship. This binary variable equals one if the mayor in a given city-year is affiliated with the Republican Party and zero otherwise. This variable serves as the primary explanatory variable used in the empirical analysis.

4 Methodology

4.1 Unit of Analysis

To examine whether mayoral partisanship influences housing market outcomes, I construct a city-level panel dataset covering multiple U.S. cities over the period 2005–2019. The unit of analysis is the city-year. This panel structure allows the analysis to exploit within-city variation over time while controlling for persistent differences across cities. By observing each city across multiple years, the analysis can examine how changes in political leadership are associated with subsequent changes in housing market outcomes.

4.2 Dependent Variables

The primary outcome of interest is housing market performance, measured using median home values. Because housing prices vary widely across cities and exhibit long-run growth trends, the analysis focuses on forward-looking percentage changes in median home values rather than levels.

Specifically, I construct several dependent variables measuring the percent change in median home value over different time horizons. These forward-looking measures allow the analysis to test whether partisan leadership is associated with short- or medium-term housing price appreciation.

4.3 Independent Variable

The key independent variable is mayoral partisanship. In the empirical specification, this is represented by an indicator variable equal to one if the city's mayor is affiliated with the Republican Party and zero otherwise. This variable captures the partisan identity of the executive municipal officeholder in each city-year.

4.4 Empirical Specification

To estimate the relationship between mayoral partisanship and housing price growth, the analysis uses panel regression models with city and year fixed effects. City fixed effects control for time-invariant characteristics of cities such as geography, long-run housing supply constraints, and historical development patterns. Year fixed effects account for nationwide shocks affecting housing markets, including macroeconomic conditions and national housing cycles.

The general specification is:

$$PriceGrowth_{it+h} = \beta RepublicanMayor_{it} + \alpha_i + \gamma_t + \epsilon_{it}$$

where $PriceGrowth_{it+h}$ represents the percent change in median home value in city i over horizon h, $RepublicanMayor_{it}$ indicates the partisan affiliation of the mayor, α_i denotes city fixed effects, and γ_t represents year fixed effects.

Standard errors are clustered at the city level to account for serial correlation within cities over time.

4.5 Identification Considerations

A key identification challenge is that political outcomes may be endogenous to local economic conditions. For example, voters may elect different types of political leaders in re-

sponse to changes in housing markets or broader economic trends. Such dynamics could bias estimates of the relationship between mayoral partisanship and housing price growth.

The inclusion of city and year fixed effects mitigates some sources of omitted variable bias by controlling for time-invariant city characteristics and nationwide economic shocks. However, the results should be interpreted as descriptive associations rather than definitive causal estimates.

Future work could strengthen causal identification using designs such as regression discontinuity in close mayoral elections, event-study analyses around mayoral transitions, or additional controls capturing housing policy decisions and development activity.

5 Results & Findings

Table 1 presents some summary of the data.

Table 1: Summary statistics

Statistic	N	Mean	St. Dev.	Min	Pctl(25)	Median	Pctl(75)	Max
Median Home Value	1,178	287,548.70	193,937.30	63,900	156,675	226,300	350,300	1,163,900
Republican	1,178	0.47	0.50	0	0	0	1	1
1 year	1,104	2.54	12.82	−40.69	−3.16	2.75	8.87	83.74
2 years	1,030	4.33	17.09	−52.60	−5.87	4.09	14.79	74.21
3 years	956	5.66	20.87	−55.02	−6.06	4.94	19.59	93.02
4 years	882	7.68	26.38	−59.14	−9.64	6.55	26.33	94.21
5 years	808	9.82	31.10	−61.14	−11.12	6.56	32.20	110.16

Table 2 presents some summaries of the performance of the model.

Table 2: Effect of mayoral partisanship on future home price growth

	Dependent variable:				
	1-year	2-year	3-year	4-year	5-year
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Republican mayor	−1.149	2.028	2.173	1.568	0.361
	(2.533)	(1.408)	(2.238)	(3.923)	(3.778)
City FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
SEs	Clustered by city	Clustered by city	Clustered by city	Clustered by city	Clustered by city
Observations	1,104	1,030	956	882	808
R^2	0.197	0.366	0.507	0.506	0.517
Adjusted R^2	0.127	0.307	0.457	0.452	0.458

Note: Outcomes are forward-looking percent changes in median home value. Standard errors clustered by city.

Table 1 presents summary statistics for the main variables used in the analysis. The average median home value across cities in the sample is approximately $287,549, with substantial variation across cities, as indicated by a standard deviation of over $193,000. The minimum observed median home value is roughly $63,900, while the maximum exceeds $1.16 million, highlighting the large differences in housing market conditions across U.S. cities.

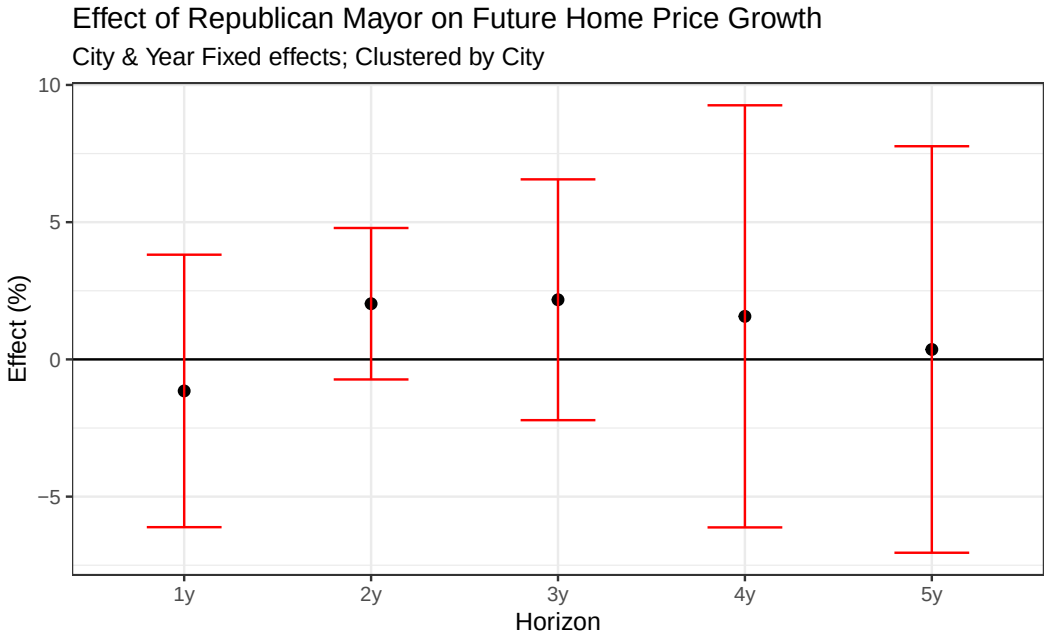


Figure 1: Estimated effect of Republican mayor

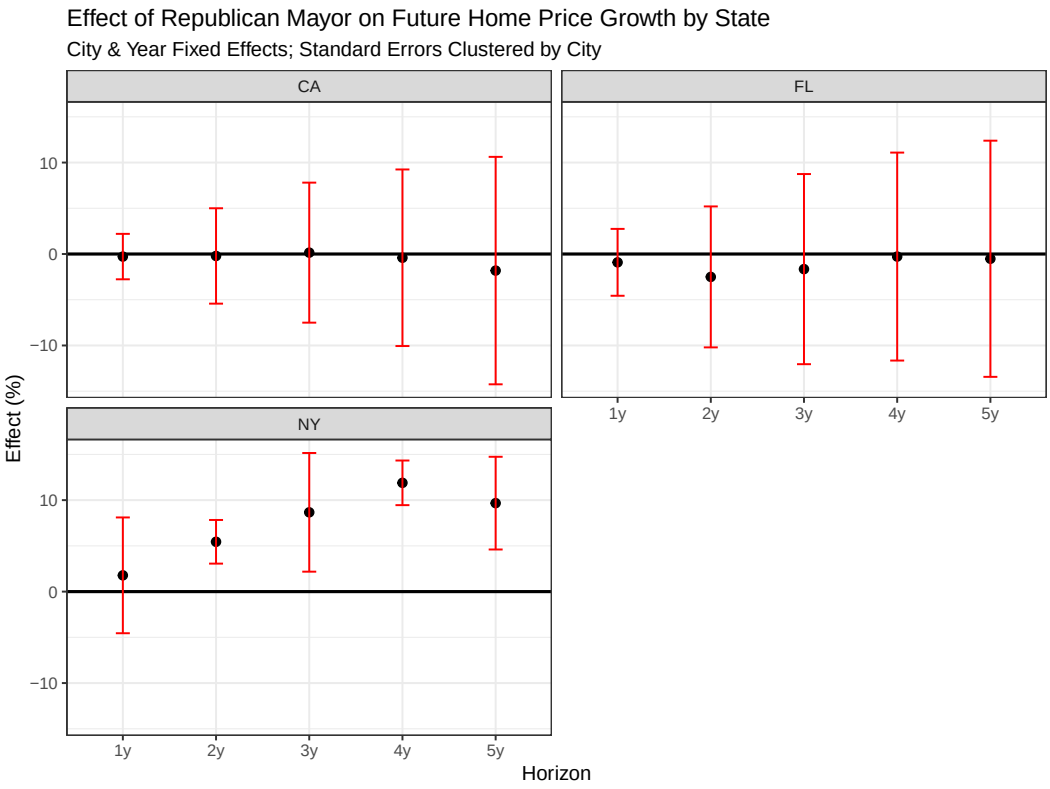


Figure 2: Estimated effect of Republican mayor

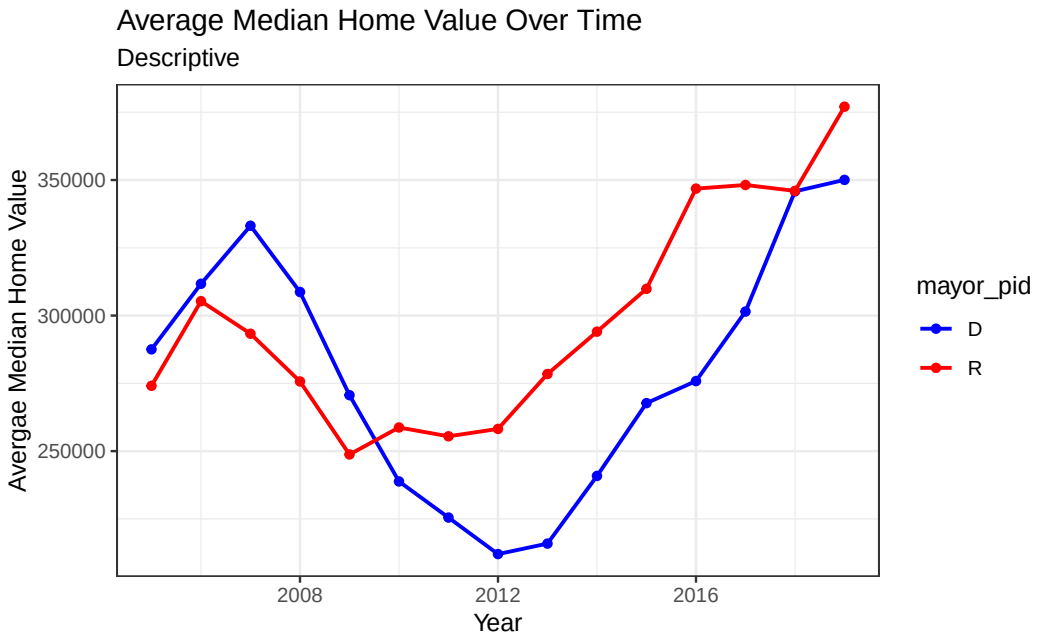


Figure 3: Mean median home value by mayor party

The partisan indicator variable shows that approximately 47 percent of city-year observations are governed by Republican mayors. This distribution provides meaningful variation in mayoral partisanship across the sample period. The forward-looking housing price growth variables reveal positive average growth across all time horizons. On average, median home values increase by approximately 2.54 percent one year ahead and roughly 9.82 percent five years ahead. However, the large standard deviations and wide minimum values indicate that housing markets also experience substantial volatility and occasional declines.

Table 2 presents the main regression results estimating the relationship between mayoral partisanship and future housing price growth. Across the one- to five-year horizons, the estimated coefficients for Republican mayors vary in both magnitude and sign. In the one-year horizon specification, the coefficient on Republican mayor is negative (-1.149), suggesting that cities governed by Republican mayors experience slightly lower short-term housing price growth. However, the estimate is small relative to the standard error and is not statistically distinguishable from zero.

For longer time horizons, the estimated coefficients become positive. The two-year and three-year horizons show positive coefficients of 2.028 and 2.173 respectively, suggesting modestly higher housing price growth under Republican mayors. The four-year and five-year estimates remain positive but smaller in magnitude. Nevertheless, none of these estimates are statistically significant at conventional levels, indicating that the analysis does not detect a consistent or robust relationship between mayoral partisanship and future housing price growth.

Figure 1 visualizes the estimated coefficients and their confidence intervals across the different time horizons. The point estimates fluctuate around zero, and the confidence intervals consistently cross the zero line. This pattern reinforces the regression results by illustrating

that the estimated effects are statistically imprecise and cannot rule out either positive or negative impacts of mayoral partisanship on housing price growth.

Figure 2 further explores whether the relationship between mayoral partisanship and housing outcomes varies across states. The figure presents separate coefficient estimates for selected states, including California, Florida, and New York. While some state-level patterns appear to differ—for example, the estimates for New York appear more positive at longer horizons—the confidence intervals remain wide across all states. As a result, the analysis does not provide strong evidence that partisan effects systematically differ across geographic contexts.

Finally, Figure 3 presents trends in mean median home values over time by mayoral party affiliation. The figure illustrates that housing values generally increase over the sample period regardless of mayoral party. The upward trend appears similar for cities governed by Republican and Democratic mayors, suggesting that broader national housing market forces likely dominate any potential partisan effects at the municipal level.

Taken together, these results suggest that mayoral partisanship does not have a clear or statistically significant relationship with future housing price growth across U.S. cities during the period studied. While the direction of the estimated effects varies across time horizons and geographic contexts, the overall pattern indicates that housing market outcomes are likely driven primarily by broader economic forces rather than the partisan identity of local political leadership.

6 Discussion & Interpretations

6.1 Interpretation of Results

The regression results suggest that mayoral partisanship does not have a strong or consistent effect on future housing price growth across cities. While some model specifications show small differences between Republican- and Democratic-led cities, the estimated coefficients are generally modest in magnitude and statistically indistinguishable from zero. Across the one- to five-year horizons examined, the direction of the estimated effects varies, and the associated confidence intervals are wide, indicating substantial uncertainty in the estimates. Although the estimated effects are not statistically significant, it is important to consider whether the range of values contained within the confidence intervals could still correspond to economically meaningful changes in housing prices. Even relatively small percentage differences in housing prices may matter for affordability. For example, a two percent change in median home values would represent several thousand dollars for the typical homebuyer given the average home prices in the dataset. As a result, while the results do not provide strong statistical evidence of partisan effects, they do not entirely rule out the possibility of economically meaningful impacts on housing affordability.

Taken together, these findings suggest that the partisan affiliation of a city's mayor is not a major determinant of housing price dynamics in the sample analyzed. Instead, housing

prices appear to be driven primarily by broader economic and structural forces that operate beyond the control of municipal leadership.

Housing markets are influenced by a wide range of factors, including national interest rates, regional labor market conditions, population growth, migration patterns, and the availability of developable land. These forces often operate at the metropolitan or national scale and can overwhelm the effects of local policy decisions. Even when mayors influence zoning decisions, development approvals, or housing policy initiatives, these actions may take several years to affect housing supply and prices. As a result, short- to medium-term price dynamics may reflect macroeconomic conditions more strongly than local political leadership.

Additionally, institutional constraints may limit the ability of mayors to directly shape housing markets. In many cities, housing policy decisions are shared among multiple actors, including city councils, planning boards, and state governments. Zoning regulations and land-use policies are often highly path dependent and difficult to change quickly. Consequently, even when mayors have distinct ideological preferences regarding development or regulation, their ability to implement large-scale policy changes may be constrained by existing institutions and political coalitions.

6.2 Do the Findings Answer the Research Question?

This project examined whether mayoral partisanship predicts future housing price growth across U.S. cities. The empirical results provide limited evidence supporting a systematic relationship between partisan leadership and housing market outcomes. Although some estimates suggest small differences across partisan leadership, the overall pattern indicates that these differences are not statistically significant and do not consistently persist across time horizons.

These findings suggest that while political ideology may influence local policy preferences, such differences do not necessarily translate into measurable changes in housing price growth within the time frame analyzed. Housing markets are complex systems shaped by structural economic forces, long-term regulatory frameworks, and demographic trends that extend beyond the influence of individual political leaders.

However, the absence of strong statistical effects should not necessarily be interpreted as evidence that politics plays no role in housing markets. Instead, it may indicate that the channels through which political leadership affects housing outcomes are indirect or operate over longer time horizons than those captured in this study. Political leadership may influence zoning reforms, development incentives, or affordable housing programs that gradually shape housing supply and neighborhood composition over time.

Future research could build on this analysis by examining additional mechanisms linking political leadership to housing markets. For example, studies could analyze whether partisan leadership influences housing construction permits, zoning reforms, or affordable housing development. Alternative empirical strategies, such as regression discontinuity designs in close mayoral elections or event-study approaches around political transitions, may also

provide stronger causal identification of political effects.

Overall, the results of this study suggest that housing market dynamics are largely driven by broader economic forces rather than the partisan identity of municipal leadership, at least within the time horizons and empirical framework examined here.

6.3 Limitations

Several limitations of this analysis should be acknowledged. First, the empirical design relies on observational data and therefore cannot fully establish a causal relationship between mayoral partisanship and housing price dynamics. Although the inclusion of city and year fixed effects helps control for time-invariant differences across cities and nationwide housing market shocks, unobserved factors that vary over time within cities may still influence both political outcomes and housing markets. For example, local economic growth, migration flows, or large development projects could simultaneously affect housing prices and electoral outcomes.

Second, the measure of political leadership used in this study focuses only on the partisan affiliation of the mayor. However, housing policy in many cities is shaped by a broader set of political actors and institutions, including city councils, planning commissions, and state governments. Because zoning changes, development approvals, and housing programs often require cooperation among multiple governing bodies, mayoral ideology alone may not fully capture the political forces shaping housing supply decisions.

Third, the analysis examines housing price growth over horizons of one to five years. While this time frame captures medium-term housing dynamics, the effects of political leadership on housing markets may operate over longer time horizons. Changes to zoning regulations, infrastructure investments, or housing development pipelines can take many years to influence the housing stock and market prices. As a result, some political effects may not be observable within the period examined in this study.

Finally, the dataset focuses on a subset of U.S. cities with available political and housing data. Housing markets vary widely across metropolitan areas in terms of geography, land availability, and regulatory environments. These structural differences may limit the generalizability of the findings to other cities or regions not included in the sample.

These limitations suggest that the results should be interpreted cautiously and primarily as descriptive associations rather than definitive causal estimates.

7 Conclusions & Future Work

This study examined whether mayoral partisanship influences housing market outcomes across U.S. cities. Using a panel dataset of cities from 2005 to 2019, the analysis evaluated whether cities governed by Republican versus Democratic mayors experience systematically different trajectories in median home value growth. By estimating regression models with

city and year fixed effects, the empirical strategy sought to isolate the relationship between partisan leadership and forward-looking housing price dynamics.

The results provide limited evidence that mayoral partisanship has a meaningful effect on housing price growth. Across one- to five-year horizons, the estimated coefficients for Republican mayors vary in direction and magnitude but remain statistically indistinguishable from zero. Visualizations of the estimated effects similarly indicate wide confidence intervals and substantial uncertainty. These findings suggest that housing market outcomes are largely shaped by broader economic forces rather than the partisan identity of local political leadership.

The results contribute to the literature on local political economy by examining whether political leadership affects observable housing market outcomes rather than only policy inputs such as spending allocations or regulatory decisions. While prior research demonstrates that partisan leadership can influence local policy priorities, the findings of this study suggest that such differences do not necessarily translate into measurable differences in housing price growth within the time horizons examined.

More broadly, the analysis highlights the complexity of housing markets and the many structural forces that shape housing affordability in the United States. National economic conditions, demographic trends, and regional supply constraints may play a larger role in determining housing price dynamics than municipal political leadership alone. Future research could further explore how local political institutions influence housing supply decisions, zoning reforms, and development activity, which may represent more direct channels through which political leadership affects housing markets.

7.1 Future Work and Extensions

Future research could extend this analysis in several ways. First, incorporating measures of state-level partisanship may provide a broader understanding of how political environments influence housing markets. State governments often control important policy areas related to housing, such as zoning authority, taxation, and development regulations, which may shape housing supply and prices more directly than municipal leadership. Another way is examining the interaction between executive and legislative political control could provide additional insights. For example, the policy impact of a mayor may depend on whether the city council shares the same partisan alignment. Accounting for unified or divided government at the municipal level could help identify situations where political leadership has greater capacity to influence housing policy and development decisions.

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